EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Two Gods or One? Saadiah Against the Rival Theories of Creation

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 1:3

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 1 (Creation), Chapter 3: the first of the rival theories (eternal matter, creation from God Himself, the combination of the two, and dualism) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 6 May 2024, on Zoom (the first shiur after Pesach)

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Three Premises

Since the start of the year the class had learned Rav Saadia's **Introduction** and begun **Essay 1, on creation**. Before Pesach Rav Saadia had established three premises:

Chapter	Premise
1	**The world is finite: there was a beginning**, against those who say it is eternal
2	**That beginning was caused by something external**, not by the universe itself
2	**The external Creator made it from nothing**

"That's his theory, and his belief, which he believes is the Torah's belief, and the opinion of the vast majority of the Rishonim." (Who that Creator is, God, "we haven't talked about yet. That's going to be Essay 2.")

Chapter 3: twelve rival theories

Now that I have established these **three roots** by reasoning, and they are verified by the words of our prophets, I will bring **twelve** other opinions. I will explain each, bring their proofs, refute them, and where I can, bring verses against them as well.

As agreed before Pesach, the class would **not** go through the whole long chapter in detail. The Rabbi would give background to each theory, read parts inside, and aim for five or six tonight. The labels for the schools (Upanishads, Sankhya, Mani) are the Rabbi's identifications.

Theory 1: Plato: Creation from Eternal Matter

The Creator made all things from **eternal, very fine matter**, and from it He fashioned this complex universe.

Why they held it: "How can a creator create from nothingness? Surely a creator has to create from something." To them creation from nothing seemed absurd, even for God. So they posited **very fine matter, as eternal as Hashem**, from which He made the world. Rav Saadia describes in detail how they thought God then shaped it, "quite complex; I'm not going to go into all of it."

Four refutations

#	Refutation	The point
1	**You have never seen eternal matter either**	Your whole reason was that we have never seen something made from nothing. But **we have never seen this eternal matter** either. Positing it is as unreasonable as what you were running from
2	**Matter without form?**	Hot and cold, moist and dry, appearance, taste, boundaries, more and less, **place and time**: all these belong to physical, finite matter and came **after** creation. So the eternal matter had **none of them**. How can matter exist with no form at all? "A direct replica of **Aristotle's argument against Plato**: you can't have matter without form"
3	**From formless to formed?**	How could something with **no length, width or depth** become something with them, and the four elements of **fire, air, water and earth**? "If you say God can do that, take what has no form and give it form, **then He can also create something from nothing**. So why are you running away?"
4	**Why the stages?**	On Plato's account God had to go through **a whole complex series of creations** to produce the universe. If He can create, why does He need the process? And if He can only work in stages, He is limited

Rav Saadia also brings **two verses** that people used as proofs for Plato's view, and rejects both readings. "Stay away from this falsehood."

Theory 2: Creation from God Himself

The Rabbi identified this with **the Upanishads**, the Hindu teachings from around **600 BCE**, "a good 2,500 years ago." (A participant on Zoom asked him to spell it: U-P-A-N-I-S-H-A-D-S.)

The Creator made the world from Himself.

(An aside on language: "I normally try to avoid using pronouns for HaKadosh Baruch Hu. Not for modern-day reasons, but because Hashem has no pronouns. He isn't a he or a she. But for simplicity's sake, we'll use He.")

Their reasoning:

1. They **accept a Creator**.
2. They **reject creation from nothing**.
3. They **reject Plato**: there was no eternal matter.
4. So there was **nothing but God**, and He must have made the world **out of Himself**.

"Have mercy on such people," says Rav Saadia. **"They are more foolish than the previous ones."**

After restating the general arguments of Chapters 1 and 2, he gives **five new ones**.

The class tries first

The Rabbi asked for logical objections before reading on. A participant suggested that **God would then be incomplete**, having taken part of Himself out. "You could argue that."
Flora raised **tzimtzum**: "Hashem contracted Himself to make room for the world." "Excellent. I was going to come on to that at the end."

Rav Saadia's five arguments

1. The limitless cannot make limits out of itself.

It is absurd that something with **no form, no characteristics, no location, no time, no properties** could turn **itself** into something with all of them. "Only someone very stupid can think something like this."

But can't God do anything? "**God can't do literally anything.**"

Can God create a stone so heavy He cannot lift it? If He can, He cannot lift it; if He cannot, He cannot create it. Either way, a deficiency?

"This is purely an issue of **semantics**. We associate the word *can't* with something negative. That's not true. Not every *can't* is a deficiency. **I'm so healthy, I can't catch the flu.** That's not a deficiency in me; that's something positive." Because Hashem is so complete and can lift anything, **He cannot create something He cannot lift**, and that is no more a deficiency "than saying God can't catch the flu."

So too: in Rav Saadia's purely rationalist mind, the limitless essence of the Creator **cannot make from itself** a world of limitations.

2. Why would anyone limit himself? If you had all power and everything you wanted, why would you turn part of yourself into physical things that **hunger and thirst** and suffer every deficiency?

3. Why put part of Himself in pain? Before creation everything is perfect. Why send part of Himself into suffering? Either it was a punishment for something that part did, or it was for no reason, "which also doesn't make sense."

4. Who chose which part? If God is one, who decided which part would go? Was one part better than another? Did it go out of fear, or hope? "That's all ridiculous."

5. Why not rescue it? Once the Creator saw that part of Him was suffering in the physical world, surely He would want to **redeem it**.

"Essentially, Saadia's argument is that it's irrational to assume that the Creator can make from Himself, who has no limitations and no form, something with form and limitations."

Tzimtzum and Rav Saadia

The Rabbi returned to Flora's point.

Historical context first. Rav Saadia wrote in the tenth century, "long before Kabbalah has any public appearance." He showed no knowledge of it. The **Zohar** came to public light only in the **1300s** (attributed to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai a thousand years earlier), and the doctrine of ***tzimtzum*** comes only from **the Arizal**, about 500 years ago.

The doctrine. Before creation there was only God, permeating all existence. (The Hachamim warned against dwelling on "before" creation, since it is so hard for finite minds within time to think about the infinite.) So the Arizal asked: **how was there room for a universe?** His answer: ***tzimtzum***, from ***letzamtzem***, to make smaller, to withdraw. **Hashem withdrew**, and the whole universe, planets and galaxies, exists within that withdrawal.

	Theory 2 (refuted by Rav Saadia)	**The Arizal's *tzimtzum***
Claim	God made the world **out of Himself**	God **withdrew** to leave a "safe space"
The world is made from	God's own essence	**Nothing**: the Arizal believes in creation from nothing
Why	Nothing else to make it from	If the world were within God, **everything would be perfect**; there could be no failures or evil

"*Chas veshalom* to say that God could take from Himself and make the universe from Himself. **No one would accept that in Jewish thinking.** That, as Saadia argued, is philosophically ridiculous."

Would Rav Saadia accept *tzimtzum*? "I highly doubt it." Some of his arguments would refute it too. He would say instead that just as God created something from nothing, He was able to create a place for the universe to exist, **not by withdrawing Himself**. "All I'm pointing out is that the Arizal's theory is **similar, although different**."

God in pain? One of Rav Saadia's arguments was: why would the Creator put part of Himself under suffering? The Rabbi recalled Chazal's reading of **עמו אנכי בצרה** (Tehillim 91:15), "I am with him in distress," from which they learn that the Shechinah goes into exile with us, as it were. "Saadia rationally makes very strong arguments. I'm just saying there are elements in other Jewish thinkers which could answer some of these points": the idea that, for humans to go through their lives, Hashem puts Himself, as it were, under some pain too.

Theory 3: The Combination

"Very short and very simple." The Rabbi identified it with **the Indian Sankhya** school:

The Creator made the world **both** from eternal matter (like Plato) **and** from Himself.

Rav Saadia does not rehash anything: **all the arguments against the first two theories apply to this one.** Rejected.

Theory 4: Dualism: Two Creators

"I'm going to spend some time on this, to the end of the shiur, because **the Hachamim of the Talmud were very much aware of this**, and they sought in many different ways to prevent us from believing it."

Background

This is **Gnostic dualism**, associated with the Iranian teacher **Mani**, from whom **Manichaeism** takes its name. It was extremely prevalent in the centuries before Rav Saadia and spread from Iran to other lands.

There are two creators: a creator of good and a creator of evil.

Why was it attractive? Because of **the hardest question in theology**:

"If God is perfect, how can there be bad in this world? This is probably the most difficult philosophical issue for theologians, whoever they may be: Jewish, Christian, Muslim. **How can a perfect and good God create suffering and evil?**" There are solutions, and Rav Saadia will have his own, "but the much easier way out of all of this is to say: very simple. There are two creators."

Elements of this appear in some strands of early Christianity: a **god of light** and a **god of darkness**, with the god of darkness giving the covenant to Israel and the god of light the "new covenant."

"By the way, this is a very black-and-white approach to life. You can't accept that **things are grey**, that things have a mixture of good and bad in them. So you say there's a good creator and all good comes from him, and a bad creator and all bad comes from him."

How Chazal fought it

Where	What	Why
Mishnah, Berachot	A chazan who says **"*modim, modim*"** twice is silenced and removed	He seems to be thanking **two** powers
The morning blessing	Shacharit's main section opens **יוצר אור ובורא חשך**	We have just passed from darkness to light. "So the night was the time of the god of darkness and now it's the god of light?" **No: the same God creates both**
The evening blessing	Arvit opens **אשר בדברו מעריב ערבים**, He rolls away light before darkness	As the light fades, we might think the god of darkness is returning to power. No: **the same God**

The Talmud also records many stories of people who **challenged the Hachamim** with this belief.

Flora pointed to the verse behind the blessing, **יוצר אור ובורא חשך עשה שלום ובורא רע** (Yeshayahu 45:7): He forms light and creates darkness, makes peace **and creates evil**. The Rabbi agreed that the wording of the blessing softens the verse, since it would be too difficult for people in the morning prayer, "because of the polemic."

Another participant offered a thought: **God has to create bad as well as good, because if everything were good, nobody would know it is good.** "You mean as a contrast. Lovely, thank you. There is an idea like that: you can only appreciate light from the darkness."

Rav Saadia's text

They are more foolish than all who came before them. They could not accept that **one agent can make two opposite kinds of things**. They saw that everything in the world is **a mixture of good and bad**, beneficial and harmful, and concluded the good comes from the good god and the bad from the bad.

Part of the theory, as Rav Saadia reports it: the **good god** is unbounded in **five directions** (above, east, west, south and north) but bounded **below**, where the evil god's realm begins; the **evil god** is unbounded below and in the four directions but bounded **above**, where the good god is. The two **mixed together and made the universe**. Why? Some said the good god wanted to **heal** the evil one, a kind of peace treaty; others that the evil god felt left out, wanted some of the good, and **hijacked** it.

"As you can see, it sounds ridiculous. But this was a very prevalent and common belief."

The refutations

Rav Saadia gives **many arguments** (the Rabbi counted about fifteen) and did not read them all. The main points:

- **One person, two natures.** A single human being can be angry one moment and appeased and forgiving the next. **We don't say he is two different personalities.** One thing can contain different aspects. "Not that he's suggesting God is bad. What he's saying is: **just because you find good and bad in the world doesn't mean there must be two creators.**"
- **Why would good associate with evil?** If you are good, you do not want to mix with evil. If it had no choice, it is not all-powerful. And if it was to make the bad good, it failed: the world is still a mixture.

Is darkness a creation at all?

Then something very interesting, "and here amongst the Hachamim we have different opinions":

Rav Saadia argues that darkness is not a creation in its own right.

	Darkness as a *beri'ah* (a creation)	Darkness as a *he'der* (an absence)
Meaning of "Hashem created night"	Hashem created a positive thing called darkness	When light withdraws, **we call that absence darkness**
Consequence	Leaves room to imagine a god of light and a god of darkness	**Dualism has no ground**: there is nothing for a second god to make
Verses like יוצר אור ובורא חשך	Literal	Hashem creates **the circumstances** in which darkness occurs, through the withdrawal of light

Rav Saadia goes into detail to prove the second view. But "it's not so clear that everyone agrees," and there are **practical halachic differences**. Very briefly: **Rabbeinu Tam's** opinion that nightfall is **72 minutes after sunset**, much later than the view we follow, which allows certain things much later in the evening. Some have argued that this rests on his understanding that **night is a creation in itself**, coming about in stages. "I don't want to go into the details. In short, I'm just pointing out that the theory that darkness is a withdrawal is not something everyone agrees to."

Summary

1. **The three premises** of Chapters 1 and 2: a beginning; an external cause; creation from nothing. **Chapter 3** now tests **twelve rival theories**.
2. **Plato (eternal matter):** we have never seen such matter either; **matter cannot exist without form**; if God can give form to the formless, He can create from nothing; and why the elaborate stages?
3. **Creation from God Himself** (which the Rabbi identified with the Upanishads): the limitless cannot make limits of itself (**the stone God cannot lift** is semantics, like "I can't catch the flu"); why would God limit Himself, suffer, choose a part, or leave it unredeemed? **The Arizal's *tzimtzum* is similar but different**: withdrawal and creation from nothing, not creation *out of* God. Rav Saadia would probably still reject it.
4. **The combination** (Sankhya): refuted by the same arguments.
5. **Dualism (Mani):** two gods of good and evil, the easy way out of the problem of evil. Chazal fought it in the **Mishnah** (*modim modim*) and **in our blessings** (*yotzer or uvorei choshech*). Rav Saadia: one person can have two natures; why would good join evil? And **darkness is only an absence**, a point on which the Hachamim differ (**Rabbeinu Tam**'s 72 minutes).

Coming Up

Next week: the remaining theories, "much quicker, because some of them are quite bizarre," aiming to finish the chapter so the class can move on to the next essay. "We've already established scientifically nowadays that there was a creation, so we shouldn't spend too long on this."

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